Mr Snook
Planning Department
Watt Tyler House
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Swindon SN1 2JH

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Emai[redacted]

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Dear Mr Snook

Re. Application No. S/OUT/13/1555

I wish to object to aspects of the above planning application, on the grounds that the plans as proposed will, in my opinion, fundamentally negate the character of South Marston, increase the volume of traffic through the village to an unacceptable level, leading to severe congestion, increase pollution, have an irreversible, negative effect on wildlife and pose a substantial risk of flooding to existing residents.

I am specifically concerned that the proposed development in the field behind Manor Meadows, Manor Park and Ash Gardens is too close to the existing houses in these roads. This field and its hedgerows is a haven for wildlife and should be preserved as a buffer between the existing houses and any new development. If development is allowed to proceed on this land the rural ambiance of the village will be compromised for many residents, wildlife will be marginalised and to many of us our village will become yet another bland suburb. I am concerned that the inevitable noise from new homes developed on this field, and accompanying traffic, will ruin the peace and tranquillity of the village. Furthermore, if the style of housing that seems to prevail today – namely dense developments of town houses on three storeys with little or no front garden - is indicative of the proposal for the field in question, this will be entirely out of keeping with the surrounding area. In my opinion it will also pose a serious food risk, thanks to what is likely to be a disproportionate ratio of hard-standing to porous green space.

The majority of residents have chosen to live in South Marston because of its peaceful location and do not wish to become absorbed into a homogenous satellite development, which shows scant respect for their quality of life or the needs of wildlife.

Roads and Traffic

I am surprised to see that there are two roads planned for Rowborough off Old Vicarage Lane, which is contrary to previous requests to have no direct road access. I believe that if these roads are approved South Marston will most definitely be used at a rat-run for Rowborough traffic. Equally, existing roads might be used by Rowborough traffic to cut through South Marston to the Key Point roundabout exit, particularly during the morning and evening rush hours and during times of heavy congestion on the A420. As it is, Thornhill Road and Highworth Road are all too often used by traffic going to South Marston Park, instead of using the A419, which poses a real danger, particularly in areas of the village where pavements do not exist. The number of HGVs already driving through South Marston, thanks to unreliable satellite navigation systems, makes it equally likely that existing

and new roads through the village will be used inappropriately by heavy goods or delivery vehicles, rather than accessing Rowborough via the A420.

There appears to be no reference to speed limits on any new roads and I would like to propose a mandatory 20mph limit on all new roads, and to see this enforced on the existing Thornhill and Highworth Roads, at least until exiting South Marston.

I do not believe that the impact of increased traffic at the already busy Gablecross and White Hart roundabouts has been researched sufficiently. The density of traffic along Oxford Road is, at the best of times, dispiriting, but during peak periods and at weekends it becomes often unviable to use this road into Swindon. The development of over 2,000 homes, with residents seeking to get to the centre of Swindon will put further pressure on this already over-used route and cause unacceptable noise, pollution and frustration for residents of Oxford Road and the adjacent side roads.

Astonishingly, I can see no firm commitment on the part of the developer to build a tunnel to ease anticipated traffic congestion at Rowborough and am most concerned that Swindon Borough Council should make this a condition of any planning application. No doubt, developers will argue that they need to sell a certain number of properties before they will agree to fund the development of a tunnel. Has such a trigger-point been established, I wonder? A cast-iron guarantee is required by the developer that this tunnel will be built, with evidence that sufficient money has been put aside specifically for this project, before any other work commences, to ensure that this tunnel is built. All too often developers sugar the pill with promises of infrastructure that fails to materialise as building work progresses. The residents of South Marston and the new Rowborough village are relying on the Council to make it a condition of approval that the tunnel will be built and that the developer will not be allowed to argue further down the line that they have exhausted their funds.

Flooding

I note that a number of objections have been raised concerning the potential flood risk of any new development and, of equal concern, a letter from Thames Water highlighting the inadequacy of the current waste water infrastructure for the proposed development. I note also that no building should be erected within three metres of a public sewer. The risk of flooding, combined with the potential overloading of waste water pipes poses a very serious threat to the health and well-being of all residents. As we know, South Marston is vulnerable to flooding and many residents have, understandably, already expressed deep concerns that adequate flood prevention measures should be implemented, alongside any future development.

Infrastructure

I do not think the developers have addressed adequately the issue of essential infrastructure for residents – namely doctors' surgeries and health care. I regret to say that it is misleading that a report notes that Merchiston Surgery in Stratton St Margaret is accepting new patients (at the time the report was submitted it was recorded that 10 doctors had a patient register totalling 14,000). As any patient of the surgery knows, the waiting time to see one's own GP is already unacceptable. To provide quality and continuity of care this surgery simply cannot cope with more patients, let alone accommodate any more vehicles in its car park. The Great Western Hospital in Swindon is woefully inadequate for the needs of the existing population of Swindon and the surrounding area, let alone

able to cope with the burden of the residents of an extra 2,000-plus homes in the Eastern Villages development.

I strongly urge the planning department to consider the needs, quality of life, health and well-being of existing residents of South Marston, Bourton and Stratton St Margaret before the theoretical requirements of future residents of the Eastern Villages. The Government's identification of a national housing shortage should be addressed carefully, intelligently, respectfully and considerately – but not at any cost to existing residents. The Council has a duty to ensure that any new development has sound infrastructure in place. All too often in the past developments have proceeded without the vital infrastructure to cope with the augmented requirements of new and existing communities. Please do not let this development become another statistic in the growing catalogue of failures.

Yours sincerely

Mrs Wendy Vickery